The Friedman Team's First Time Buyer's Checklist

15 Steps to Your Front Door

Carroll, Baltimore & Howard County

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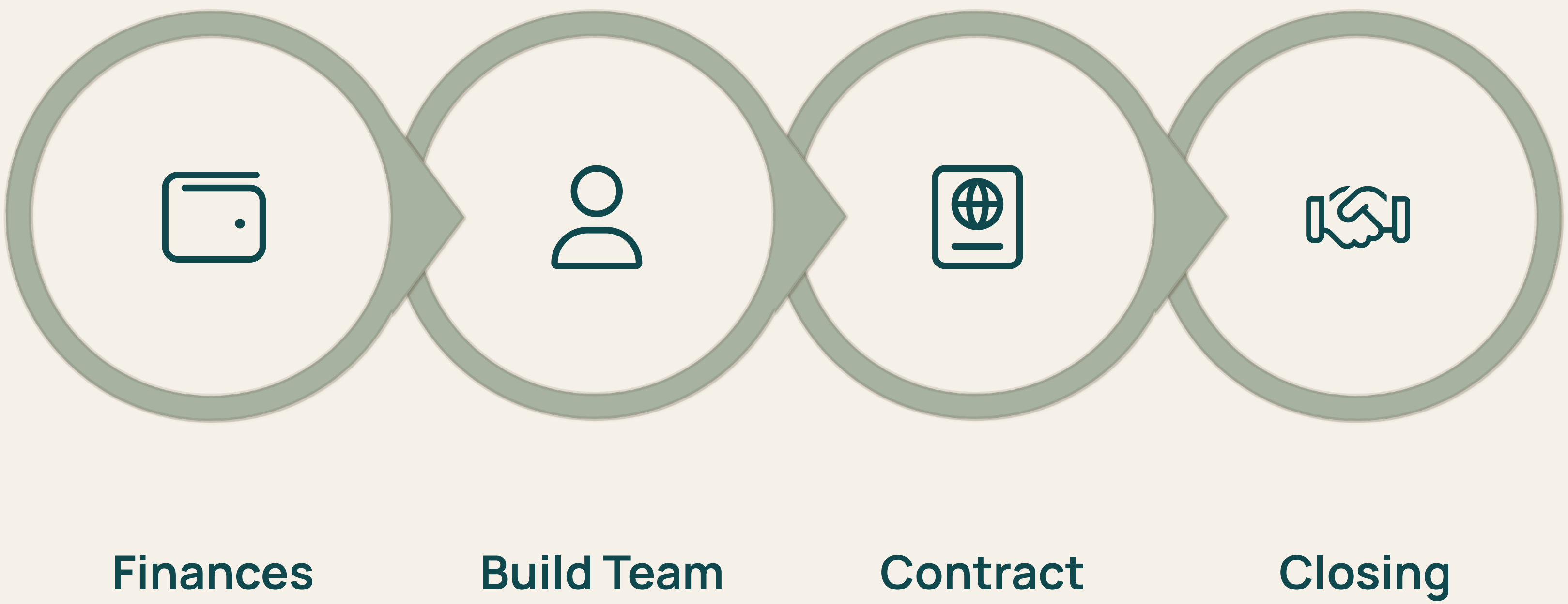
Your Roadmap to Homeownership

You've been scrolling listings for weeks. Maybe it's a rowhome in Baltimore County, a colonial with real yard space in Carroll County, or something in Howard County close enough to Columbia to make the commute work. It's exciting - and it's also a lot. Between pre-approvals, Maryland's specific inspection addendums, and closing paperwork, it's easy to lose track of what actually comes next.

This is the roadmap I walk every first-time buyer through, built specifically around how buying works in our three counties - not a generic national checklist. Fifteen steps, four phases, start to keys-in-hand.



$ PHASE 1

Get Your Finances Right First

Step 1: Know Your Real Number

What a lender approves you for and what you can comfortably afford are two different numbers. The gap is almost always property taxes, and in our area that gap moves a lot depending on where you land - Baltimore City runs meaningfully higher than the surrounding counties, and it's worth running the real math before you fall for a house. Aim to keep your total debt-to-income ratio under 43% so a mortgage doesn't quietly eat every other part of your budget. If you're looking at townhomes or condos in Howard or Baltimore County, add the HOA or condo fee into that math too - it directly changes what you can actually afford.

Step 2: Your Down Payment Is Probably Smaller Than You Think

Twenty percent avoids private mortgage insurance, but most first-time buyers I work with put down somewhere between 3-5%. Look into the Maryland Mortgage Program (MMP) - it offers real down payment assistance for eligible first-time buyers, often as a deferred, 0%-interest second loan. Separately, budget for closing costs too: typically 2-5% of the purchase price, covering transfer taxes, recordation fees, and title insurance.

Step 3: Clean Up Your Credit Before You Apply

Your score sets your interest rate, and in this rate environment that difference is real money every month. Pay down card balances so your utilization sits under 30% before you apply. And the rule that trips people up most: don't open new credit, finance furniture, or lease a car while your loan is in process. Lenders re-check before closing, and a new payment on your credit report days before settlement can genuinely blow up a deal.

PHASE 2

Build Your Team, Start Looking

1

Work With Someone Who Knows These Counties

Real estate is hyper-local. The difference between a septic system in rural Carroll County and a ground rent situation in an older Baltimore County neighborhood isn't something a generic agent thinks to check. I come at this with an investor's eye too - I spent years on the wholesale and acquisitions side before coming back to full-service brokerage, so I'm looking at a property's real bones and real numbers, not just its curb appeal.

2

Get Pre-Approved, Not Just Pre-Qualified

A pre-qualification is a guess based on what you told someone over the phone. A pre-approval is a verified number from a lender who's actually looked at your financials - and in a competitive listing, sellers frequently won't seriously consider an offer without one. I'd rather connect you with a local Maryland lender than a big national bank; local lenders know the MMP and our specific county quirks.

3

Research the Actual Neighborhood

Carroll, Baltimore, and Howard County each cover a lot of ground. Test the actual commute at actual rush hour before you commit. Check internet access if you're looking rural in Carroll County; it's not guaranteed the way it is in Howard County's more built-up areas. And weigh walkability versus space - you'll find more of the former in Howard County's planned communities, more of the latter in Carroll County.

4

Separate Must-Haves From Nice-to-Haves

Must-haves are non-negotiable: bedroom count, a specific school zone, a garage. Nice-to-haves are real value but not deal-breakers: a finished basement, a fenced yard, an updated kitchen. If you're looking at anything rural in Carroll County, confirm early whether the property has public water and sewer or relies on well and septic; that changes your inspection list.

5

Start Touring, and Look Past the Paint

Bad paint and dated decor are cheap fixes - don't let them scare you off a good structure. What actually matters is the roof's age, window condition, and how old the HVAC system is. Take photos of mechanical systems as you go so you can ask me about them later, not guess.

PHASE 3

The Contract

Step 9: Make a Real Offer, Not a Guess

When you find it, I pull the actual comparable sales in that specific neighborhood so your offer is grounded in real data, not a feeling. Your earnest money deposit - usually 1-3% of the price - shows good faith and sits in escrow until settlement. Your contingencies (financing, appraisal, inspection) are your protection if something doesn't check out.

Step 10: Negotiate Like a Conversation, Not a Fight

Almost everything is negotiable in Maryland. First-time buyers often ask sellers to cover a portion of closing costs - a "seller contribution" - which keeps more of your cash available for moving day. Counter-offers are normal, not a red flag.

Step 11: Never Skip the Inspection

Radon shows up often enough in Maryland basements that I recommend testing every time. Wood-destroying insect inspections are standard practice here and frequently required by lenders outright. And if you're anywhere rural in Carroll County, a well and septic inspection isn't optional.

Step 12: The Appraisal Is Your Safety Net

Your lender orders an independent appraisal to confirm the home's actually worth what you're paying. If it comes in low, you're not stuck - you can renegotiate the price, cover the gap in cash, or walk away entirely.

PHASE 4

Closing

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Step 13: Your Loan Gets Its Final Check

The underwriter does one more full pass on your finances before releasing "Clear to Close." You'll receive your Closing Disclosure at least three days before settlement, showing your exact rate and the precise amount of cash you'll need to bring.

02

Step 14: Title Work Catches What You Can't See

One Maryland-specific thing I check personally: "ground rent," a legal quirk in some older parts of the Baltimore area where you own the structure but lease the land underneath it. In newer subdivisions, I also check for "front foot benefit" charges - water and sewer assessments that can show up as a surprise annual bill.

03

Step 15: Maryland Does "Wet" Settlements

Unlike some states, Maryland typically closes with everyone physically at the table - buyers, sellers, and agents - signing together. Funds transfer immediately, and you walk out with keys in hand the same day.

If you're getting ready to start this process, I'm happy to walk through your specific situation.

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